



Global Peace Collapse

Assess the role of totalitarianism in the collapse of global peace in the late 30's

Introduction: The late 1930s marked a dramatic unravelling of global peace, culminating in the outbreak of World War II. While the Treaty of Versailles and the Great Depression created a fertile ground for instability, totalitarian regimes—particularly Nazi Germany, Fascist Italy, and Imperial Japan—played a decisive role in destabilising the international order. Their aggressive expansionism, ideological extremism, and rejection of collective security undermined the post-WWI framework. However, the collapse of peace was not solely their doing: economic chaos and democratic failures also paved the way for conflict. Today, we will assess how totalitarianism, alongside these factors, contributed to the breakdown of global peace.

I. Totalitarianism as the disruptor of peace

✦ Totalitarian regimes actively challenged the post-WWI order by rejecting the principles of collective security and international cooperation. Their actions were driven by expansionist ideologies and a desire for global dominance:

- **Violations of the Versailles Treaty:** Germany's remilitarisation of the Rhineland (1936), Austria's Anschluss (1938), and Italy's invasion of Abyssinia (1935) were direct breaches of the post-war settlement. These acts demonstrated a blatant disregard for international agreements and the League of Nations.
- **Aggressive Expansionism:** Japan's invasion of Manchuria (1931) and China (1937) further weakened the League's authority, as it failed to respond effectively. The appeasement policy—exemplified by the Munich Agreement (1938)—only emboldened Hitler, convincing him that aggression would go unpunished.
- **Ideological Extremism:** Totalitarian regimes promoted militarism and nationalism, justifying conquest as a means to achieve dominance. This ideology clashed with the democratic values of the League, making compromise nearly impossible.

Yet, while totalitarianism was a primary disruptor, it did not act in a vacuum. The economic and political context of the 1930s also played a critical role in enabling its rise.

II. Great Depression as a major catalyst

The Great Depression (1929) created conditions where totalitarianism could thrive, while weakening democratic resistance to aggression:

-  The global economic collapse led to mass unemployment, poverty, and social unrest. In Germany, hyperinflation and economic despair radicalised the population, making them receptive to Hitler's promises of stability and revival.
-  Countries turned inward, adopting protectionist policies (e.g., the Hawley-Smoot Tariff, 1930). This economic nationalism undermined international cooperation and fuelled tensions between nations due to its impact on global economic health.
-  The Depression discredited democracy in the eyes of many, as governments struggled to address the crisis. This loss of faith in democratic systems allowed totalitarian leaders to gain power by offering simple, radical solutions.

However, the failures of democracy themselves were equally responsible for the collapse of peace. The inaction and divisions among democratic powers allowed totalitarian regimes to act with impunity.

III. Democratic Failures as the key cause

The weaknesses of democratic powers, particularly their inaction and disunity, enabled totalitarian regimes to pursue their aggressive agendas:

-  The Sudetenland Crisis (1938) and the Munich Agreement showed that democratic powers (Britain, France) were unwilling to confront aggression directly. This appeasement signalled to Hitler that further expansion (e.g., Poland, 1939) would face no serious consequences.
-  The Sudetenland Crisis (1938) and the Munich Agreement showed that democratic powers (Britain, France) were unwilling to confront aggression directly. This appeasement signalled to Hitler that further expansion (e.g., Poland, 1939) would face no serious consequences.
-  Many democracies, traumatised by WWI, adopted a pacifist stance and reduced military spending. This moral disarmament left them unprepared to counter totalitarian expansion, as seen in the failure of the League to stop Japan, Italy, or Germany.

Conclusion: In conclusion, the collapse of global peace in the late 1930s was not the result of a single factor but rather a convergence of totalitarian ambitions, economic chaos, and democratic failures. Totalitarian regimes actively disrupted the post-WWI order through their expansionist and ideological policies. However, the Great Depression created the conditions for their rise, while the weaknesses of democratic powers allowed these regimes to act without consequence. Ultimately, peace requires not only the absence of aggression but also the presence of strong, united, and proactive democratic systems. Without these, even the most well-intentioned international frameworks can collapse.